Republicanism/communism

A second source of international thought in China arises from its republican and communist heritage. It may seem odd to club republican and communist views together. Common to both streams of thought is a rejection of traditional authority and, most importantly, the rule of kings and emperors. The republican movement that ended with General Chiang Kai-shek's defeat on the Chinese mainland in 1949 and the triumphant communist movement share a revolutionary legacy. Both movements were dedicated to the end of imperial rule in China if not the destruction of the royal household. The Son of Heaven in a tianxia world would be replaced by secular authority backed by people power. Today, China is supposedly a communist country because it is run by the Communist Party of China (CPC). In fact, it is less communist ideologically than republican – with a president who is not popularly elected but who claims his legitimacy from the will of the people. In short, China is a republican country with a communist past.

The communist past has provided a view of international relations, like tianxia, which is hierarchical. While communism envisages a world in which capitalism is overthrown and an entirely new world order is born – one that Karl Marx refused to describe, saying it was impossible to know what would emerge after the revolution – those who brought the revolution in Russia and China had little doubt that their countries would live in an international system in which capitalism was still rampant. The global struggle of communism would be a long one. In the struggle, Russia and then China would be central. Here too there were debates between internationalists who wanted to actively propagate the struggle against capitalism and those who wanted to secure the revolution at home before embarking on a global crusade. Those who stood for consolidation at home were convinced that given the size of Russia and China they would be at the centre of global revolutionary thought and praxis. They would stand as examples for other revolutionaries and would provide guidance if not material aid. This suggests another hierarchical view, a more tutelary view,